

TIDAL SURVIVAL

Seaweeds need water to make the sugar that fuels their growth. They soak it up over their entire surface instead of through roots and veins, like plants. This works only if they are underwater, but many seaweeds that grow in coastal waters are tough enough to survive a few hours of exposure on the shore at low tide. They can dry out under the hot sunshine, but soon recover as the tide rises and submerges them.



SEAWEED GRAZERS

Seaweeds provide food for a variety of sea creatures, including small crabs, sea urchins, limpets, and several types of fish. Many tropical parrotfish specialize in grazing the seaweed that grows on coral reefs, using their strong teeth to scrape it from the soft rock. This helps stop seaweeds from smothering the coral.

◀ PARROTFISH

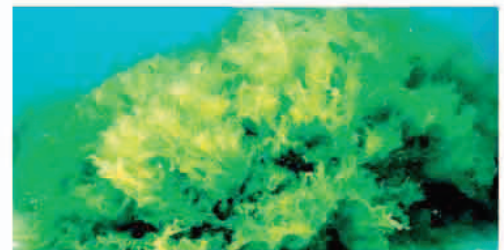
The teeth of parrotfish are fused into a strong "beak" that can crunch through coral rock to get at the small seaweeds growing on it.

TYPES OF SEAWEED

There are three types of seaweed: brown, green, and red. The difference is not just their color—they are not related, and have very different structures. Most brown seaweeds are big, tough wracks and kelps, while green seaweeds include delicate forms like sea lettuce. The red ones include coralline seaweeds that help build coral reefs.



Brown seaweed (algae)



Green seaweed (algae)



Red seaweed (algae)

